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Record-breaking heatwaves have caused wildfires in northern France, southern Spain and western United States with over 2,700 people also reported dead in England and Wales | P8-9

AP

Spain's task cut out against France's attacking arsenal

Can possession-based football match a multi-pronged strike-force?

DUBAI

BY SHAMSEER MOHAMMED
Staff Writer
ROBERT ILSLEY
Sports Reporter

It is being billed as the 'final before the final'. Spain will attempt to neutralise one of the most potent attacking arsenals in World Cup history today when they take on France in a heavyweight semi-final showdown.

The reigning European champions and Didier Des-

champs' French team face off at the AT&T Stadium in Arlington, Texas, featuring unarguably the two best sides left in the tournament.

Focus on Mbappe, Yamal

In the blue corner are France, who have progressed serenely to the last four on the back of a multi-pronged strike-force spearheaded by captain Kylian Mbappe — he has scored eight goals in six games.

Mbappe's supporting cast includes Bayern Munich star Michael Olise, Ballon d'Or winner Ousmane Dembele and Paris Saint-Germain duo Bradley Barcola and Desire Doue.

In the red corner are Spain, who have calmly worked their way into the semi-finals with

their brand of possession-based, relentless football that has become their trademark under Luis de la Fuente.

While individual brilliance has lit up France's campaign, Spain have relied on collective menace — a well-oiled machine founded on the silky passing of midfielders such as Rodri, Pedri and Fabian Ruiz, providing ammunition for teenage winger Lamine Yamal.

It all adds up to a classic clash of styles that will see Spain attempt to sever the supply lines to Mbappe and company by controlling possession, while simultaneously seeking to put pressure on a France defence that has yet to be seriously tested.

SEE ALSO P15,16

Abu Dhabi frontrunner for \$5 billion Moon resort

Founders say project needs 556-acre site

DUBAI

BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

Abu Dhabi is emerging as the only viable location in the UAE for the proposed \$5 billion Moon resort, according to the project's founders, who say the development cannot proceed without government backing and a 556-acre site.

Michael R. Henderson and Sandra G. Matthews, co-founders of Moon World Resorts Inc., told *Gulf News* that Abu Dhabi appears to offer the large land parcel required for the project after discussions with major developers, including Aldar, failed to secure a local partner.

The company said the resort would need a



1,500-metre by 1,500-metre site before a regional licence could be awarded. Moon World Resorts said it operates as an intellectual property licensor, with local partners expected to finance and build each project.

The founders estimate a UAE resort could attract 10 million visitors annually, contribute \$60 billion a year to the economy and support 60,000 jobs, though these are company projections that have not been independently verified.

SEE ALSO P-II

TRUMP REVIVES BLOCKADE ON IRAN, SEEKS HORMUZ FEES

Sirens in Bahrain; Kuwait, Jordan intercept attacks

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump yesterday announced the reinstatement of a naval blockade on Iran and declared that commercial ships using the Strait of Hormuz would have to pay the United States for protection, as renewed fighting with Tehran pushed their fragile interim agreement closer to collapse.

In a series of posts on Truth Social, Trump said Washington would once again block Iranian ships and vessels carrying Iranian cargo while allowing all other traffic to pass through the strategic waterway. "The Hormuz Strait is OPEN, and will remain OPEN, with or without Iran," Trump wrote. "We are reinstating the Iranian blockade... All other countries will have fair and open use of the Strait."

He also declared the United States would become the "guardian" of the Strait of Hormuz and charge commercial vessels 20 per cent of the value of their cargo to cover the cost of securing the waterway. "Now we're going to guard it, and we're going to get paid for guarding it," Trump said.

Dramatic shift

The announcement marked a dramatic shift from Washington's long-held position that ships should transit the strait without paying fees to any country. The competing claims came as US and Iranian forces exchanged some

HORMUZ TRAFFIC DROPS 52%

Fourteen vessels — half of them Iranian — transited the Strait of Hormuz yesterday, according to data and intelligence firm Kpler, as the US-Iran ceasefire unravels and fewer ships risk navigating the crucial waterway. Five of the seven Iranian vessels followed the route that hugs the Iranian coastline, which the Iranian regime has sought to push ships into using to ensure greater control over the strait. The other two vessels were "dark," meaning they didn't broadcast their location data as they transited the strait.

Of the other seven vessels, five were "dark," one used the Iranian route, and one used the International Maritime Organisation route that passes through the middle of the strait and was in use before the war. As the US and Iran traded more intense strikes over the weekend, 52 per cent fewer ships attempted to cross the strait than the previous week, Kpler added.

—S. N. R.

of their heaviest strikes since an April ceasefire. The US military said it attacked dozens of Iranian military targets yesterday, while Iran's Revolutionary Guards announced fresh strikes on Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait and Oman. Iran's military rejected Trump's declaration, insisting it would not allow the United States to interfere in what it called the management of the strategic waterway.

"The United States, under no circumstances, will be allowed to interfere in the management" of the Strait of Hormuz, a spokesman for Iran's Khatam Al-Anbiya military command said.

The latest escalation has further weakened the June memorandum of understanding that temporarily reopened the strait and suspended the earlier US blockade of Iranian ports.

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baqaei said the agreement was now "in crisis" after Washington's recent

actions. He warned Tehran would no longer consider itself bound by the deal if the United States continued to violate its commitments, but said indirect negotiations through mediators including Qatar, Pakistan and Oman were continuing in an effort to prevent a wider conflict.

Talks still on

Trump, meanwhile, said talks with Iran had continued for hours on Sunday but accused Tehran of backtracking on previous understandings. Air raid sirens sounded in Bahrain, Kuwait said it intercepted hostile aerial targets, and Jordan's military reported shooting down four Iranian missiles.

The renewed fighting rattled global financial markets. Brent crude rose about 4.5 per cent to around \$79.40 a barrel, while US crude climbed above \$74. Global stock markets also weakened.

— with inputs from AP, AFP
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